for most of India into the modern age. These included wheat, millet, rice, and lentils. Paired with a wide variety of vegetables and spices, these fundamental ingredients were used again and again until cooks learned how to best manipulate them in terms of longevity, flavor, and nutritional satisfaction. Ground whole wheat turned into flat, unleavened breads; lentils could be ground into flour, boiled into soups, or spiced to stand alone as a main dish. As the Harappan people spread along the Indus Valley and southward along the Sarasvati, they learned to mix a colorful collection of vegetables and fruits into their stews, including eggplant, onion, taro, mango, and tamarind.

Archeological research into the utensils and dental remains of the Harappans of ancient Farmana, situated in northern Haryana, revealed that recipes of the ancient Indians were not at all dissimilar than are in use today. Calling it a “proto-curry” of the Harappans, food writer Soiti Bannerjee extrapolated those finds into a simple recipe that would have been prepared in an earthenware pot.

Proto-Curry, circa 2000 BCE

6-7 small aubergines, washed and slit

1-inch piece of ginger, ground

1 fresh turmeric, ground, or ¼ tsp turmeric powder

Salt

1 tbsp. raw mango cut into cubes

2-3 tbsp. sesame oil

¼ tsp. cumin

Dehydrated sugarcane juice to taste

A few leaves of sweet basil (optional)

Many of the Harappans were vegetarians, probably due to the lack of domesticated animals and the plentitude of protein-rich crops in the Indus River Valley. It’s also possible that the meatless Vedic religion made its appearance during this period, before the high number of Asian migrants. Around the time of the proto-curry, the necessity to eat only plant-based foods started to change. According to collections of bones found in archaeological sites, it seems that the domesticated chicken may have started its evolutionary journey right along the floodplains of the Indus. Researchers have posited that two species of wild birds, a red junglefowl